

Where to put only

Teaching guide

Make clear what you are limiting.

Understand the distinction

Only limits a person, thing, action, amount, or time. Put it close to the element you want to limit when clarity matters: Only Jo called means nobody else called; Jo called only Sam means Sam was the only recipient.

In speech, stress and context also shape the meaning. I only bought two can be understood naturally even if only is not immediately before two. Do not assume every everyday placement is wrong; revise when a reader could misunderstand.

Compare the patterns

PERSON

Only Jo called Sam.

Nobody other than Jo called Sam.

RECIPIENT

Jo called only Sam.

Jo called no one except Sam.

ACTION

Jo only called; she did not visit.

The action was limited to a call.

Read each example. Explain what the highlighted choice means in context. Then cover the example and say a similar sentence.

Check your understanding

Write before looking at the answers. The guide gives a model answer and explains the choice. Other wording can be correct.

1. Which says Sam was the sole recipient: Only Jo called Sam / Jo called only Sam?

2. Rewrite clearly: No one except Leo replied.

3. Can spoken stress help clarify only?

Use it in your own life

Write two sentences in which moving only changes the meaning.

Self-check

Does your sentence express your intended meaning? Does its form follow the relevant pattern? Can a reader understand the context?

Try again

After checking the explanation, revise your sentence. Say it aloud or use it in a short conversation.

Answers and explanation

1. Jo called only Sam.

Only limits Sam.

2. Only Leo replied.

Only is next to the person being limited.

3. Yes. Stress and context can identify the focus.

In writing, a clearer position may help.

One possible response

Only Ana ordered tea. Ana ordered only tea.

This is a model, not the only acceptable answer. Assess meaning, grammar, and context together.

Continue learning

Web lesson and related topics: englishladder.com/grammar-concepts/concept-18.html

A practical teaching sequence

1. Notice (2 minutes)

Ask learners to explain the differences between the comparison examples before reading the rules. Use their answers to identify the point that needs attention.

2. Explain and check (4 minutes)

Read the short explanation together. Keep its qualifications: a common pattern is not necessarily a rule for every context. Ask learners to give a counterexample where the lesson mentions an exception.

3. Apply (5 minutes)

Write two sentences in which moving only changes the meaning.

Have learners work alone, then compare with a partner. Ask the partner to restate the intended meaning before suggesting a correction.

4. Review (3 minutes)

Use the answer explanations to review the three checks. Accept natural alternatives that preserve the intended meaning. Ask each learner to revise one sentence and identify the change.

Extension

Change the person, time, place, or purpose in a comparison example. Ask whether the original pattern still fits and why. Revisit one example in the next lesson.

Feedback criteria

Meaning: the message is understandable. Form: the target pattern fits the context. Transfer: the learner can use it in a fresh example. This short activity is not a proficiency certification.